

Are you familiar with the phone game, Drug Lord?

Yes. The classic **Drug Lord** (and its close cousin **Drug Wars/Dope Wars**) was a very popular text-based trading game from the 1990s. MobyGam... +1

The basic gameplay was:

- Start with a small amount of cash.
- Travel between cities.
- Buy commodities (in this case, drugs) where prices are low.
- Sell where prices are high.
- Deal with random events such as police raids, muggings, loan sharks, and market shortages.
- Grow your wealth as quickly as possible before time runs out. MobyGam... +1

Despite the theme, the game is really an economics and risk-management simulation. Many players remember it from:

- DOS computers
- Palm Pilots
- TI-82/TI-83 calculators
- Early mobile phones and PDAs Reddit +2

A typical turn looked like:

Action	Example
Check prices	Cocaine = \$20,000
Travel	Fly to another city
Random event	Police raid increases prices
Trade	Sell Cocaine for \$40,000
Upgrade	Buy larger coat/storage, weapons, etc.
Repeat	Grow your bankroll

The core strategy was simply:

Buy low, sell high, manage risk, and compound your capital.

In fact, many people jokingly say Drug Lord taught them more about **supply and demand**, **arbitrage**, and **capital management** than school economics classes did.  Reddit +1

Given your interests in trading systems and market behavior, I suspect you'd recognize that Drug Lord is essentially a simplified speculative trading game:

- Commodities = drugs
- Cities = markets
- Price spikes = volatility
- Loan sharks = leverage
- Police/muggings = risk events
- Goal = maximize account growth before the game ends

If you're asking because you have an idea related to the game, I can also explain how its mechanics could be adapted into a modern business, agriculture, sports-management, or stock-trading simulation without the drug theme.

What ideas can you add to the game to improve it?

The original Drug Lord formula is addictive because it combines **trading, risk, randomness, and progression**. However, it is quite shallow by modern standards. Here are some ideas that could make it much deeper while keeping the "buy low, sell high" gameplay.

1. Dynamic Supply and Demand

Instead of completely random prices:

- Every city produces certain goods.
- Shortages and surpluses develop naturally.
- Players can influence markets.

Example:

- Roseau produces bananas.
- Barbados imports bananas.
- If many traders buy all bananas in Roseau, prices rise.

This turns the game into a genuine economic simulation.

2. Multiple Industries

Instead of only one commodity type, allow players to trade:

- Agriculture
- Fish
- Electronics
- Fuel
- Construction materials
- Luxury goods

Each industry behaves differently.

Example:

- Fish spoil quickly.
 - Electronics lose value over time.
 - Fuel spikes after hurricanes.
-

3. Businesses Instead of Pure Trading

Allow players to:

- Buy farms
- Buy fishing boats
- Open stores
- Own warehouses
- Operate transport companies

Income comes from both:

- Trading
 - Business ownership
-

4. Reputation System

Different groups trust you differently.

Examples:

- Government
- Businesses
- Banks
- Citizens

High reputation unlocks:

- Better loans

- Contracts
- Special opportunities



Low reputation may trigger:

- Audits
- Higher taxes
- Lost business

5. Contracts and Missions

Not every trade should be speculation.

Examples:

- Deliver 500 lbs of fish within 3 days.
- Supply a football tournament.
- Provide food after a hurricane.

Rewards:

- Guaranteed profits
- Reputation gains

6. Smarter Transportation

Transportation becomes strategic.

Options:

- Bicycle
- Pickup truck
- Cargo van
- Cargo ship
- Air freight

Each has:

Vehicle	Capacity	Speed	Cost
Bike	Low	Medium	Low
Truck	Medium	Medium	Medium
Cargo Ship	Huge	Slow	High

Vehicle	Capacity	Speed	Cost
Plane	Medium	Very Fast	Very High

7. Regional and Global Markets

Instead of cities only:

- Villages
- Islands
- Countries

Examples:

- Dominica
- Martinique
- Guadeloupe
- Trinidad
- Miami

Different regulations affect trade.

8. Economic News

News influences markets.

Examples:

"Hurricane approaching Dominica"

Effects:

- Food prices rise.
- Fuel prices rise.
- Construction materials surge.

Or:

"New fishing regulations announced"

Effects:

- Fish supply drops.
- Fish prices increase.

Players must anticipate news.



9. Banking and Investing

Allow players to:

- Borrow money
- Earn interest
- Buy stocks
- Buy bonds
- Invest in startups

Now players decide:

- Trade inventory?
 - Invest capital?
 - Buy businesses?
-

10. AI Competitors

Instead of being alone:

- Other traders compete.
- They buy stock before you.
- They bid on contracts.
- They manipulate markets.

This makes each playthrough unique.

11. Political System

Governments can:

- Raise taxes
- Ban products
- Subsidize industries
- Close ports

Players must adapt.

12. Multiplayer Economy

This could be the biggest upgrade.

Players:

- Buy from each other
- Sell to each other
- Form cooperatives
- Form cartels
- Create companies

A real player-driven economy emerges.

13. Character Skills

Players level up.

Examples:

Negotiator

- Better buying prices.

Logistician

- Lower transport costs.

Analyst

- Better market forecasts.

Entrepreneur

- Businesses earn more.

This creates different playstyles.

14. Hidden Information

Players don't see every market price instantly.

Options:

- Travel to discover prices.
- Hire scouts.
- Pay for market reports.

Information itself becomes valuable.

15. Generational Mode

The ultimate endgame.

Start as:

- A small trader.

Become:

- Business owner.

Then:

- Regional company.

Then:

- International corporation.

Finally:

- Pass assets to your heir.

The game could span decades of in-game time.

A Concept That Might Fit Dominica Particularly Well

Given your interest in agriculture, fisheries, and local economic development, imagine a game called **Island Tycoon**:

- Start with EC\$5,000.
- Trade fish, bananas, coconuts, and vegetables between villages.
- Buy trucks and boats.
- Export to neighboring islands.
- Build warehouses and processing plants.
- Survive hurricanes.
- Compete against AI traders.
- Become the largest exporter in the Caribbean.

That keeps the addictive "Drug Lord" trading loop but turns it into a realistic Caribbean business simulation.

Tell me if this is possible:

I want the game to be as close to real life as possible, in terms of opportunity, third world countries compared to first world. I want the the game to have all the ideas in

economics, from different schools. Also nobel prize winning economics papers that push the boundaries on how individuals make choices, like nudge economics.

Yes, it's possible—but not in the way most simulation games attempt it.

The challenge isn't building an economy. We already know how to build markets, businesses, banks, and trade systems. The challenge is modeling **human decision-making** realistically. That's where modern economics, psychology, sociology, and political science come in.

What you're describing sounds less like Drug Lord and more like a **Civilization-level economic life simulator** focused on individuals.

The Main Problem

Most economic games assume:

People are rational and maximize profit.

Real life doesn't work that way.

A poor farmer in Dominica may choose a lower-profit crop because:

- His father grew it.
- He fears risk.
- He lacks information.
- His neighbor recommends it.
- The bank won't lend to him.
- He needs cash this week rather than more cash next year.

Modern economics increasingly studies these "irrational" behaviors.

Layer 1: Classical Economics

Include ideas from:

Adam Smith

- Supply and demand
- Competition
- Specialization

David Ricardo

- Comparative advantage

Example:

- Dominica exports bananas.
- Japan exports electronics.

Even if Japan could grow bananas better, specialization still creates trade opportunities.

Layer 2: Austrian Economics

Include:

Subjective Value

Different people value things differently.

Example:

A fisherman values:

- A boat > laptop

A software engineer values:

- Laptop > boat

Prices emerge from these preferences.

Entrepreneurship

Players discover opportunities.

Not every opportunity should be visible.

Some players notice:

- Export markets

Others don't.

Layer 3: Keynesian Economics

Introduce:

Economic Cycles

Booms

Recessions

Depressions

Governments may:

- Increase spending
- Reduce taxes
- Create jobs

Players experience the consequences.

Layer 4: Institutional Economics

This is critical.

Many countries are poor not because of resources but because of institutions.

Inspired by:

- Why Nations Fail

Examples:

Country A:

- Strong courts
- Property rights
- Reliable contracts

Country B:

- Corruption
- Weak courts
- Political favoritism

The exact same business may succeed in one country and fail in another.

Layer 5: Behavioral Economics

This is where Nobel-winning research becomes exciting.

Daniel Kahneman

People hate losses more than they enjoy gains.

Example:

Gain \$100:

- Happiness = +10

Lose \$100:

- Pain = -20

Players and AI should behave this way.

Richard Thaler

Nudge Theory.

Instead of forcing decisions:

Government:

- Automatically enrolls citizens into savings plans.

Result:

- More people save.

No laws changed.

Only defaults changed.

Present Bias

People prefer:

\$100 today

instead of

\$150 next month

even when irrational.

Very common among poor populations.

Overconfidence

Entrepreneurs frequently overestimate success.

Many businesses should fail because owners believe:



Layer 6: Development Economics

This is where first-world and third-world differences become realistic.

Inspired by:

- Abhijit Banerjee
- Esther Duflo

Key insight:

Poor people often make rational choices given their circumstances.

Example:

A farmer may avoid fertilizer because:

- One bad harvest means starvation.

Not because he doesn't understand economics.

Layer 7: Social Capital

People don't operate alone.

Trust matters.

Example:

Village A:

- High trust

Village B:

- Low trust

In Village A:

- Informal lending works

In Village B:

- Everyone demands contracts

Economic outcomes diverge dramatically.



Layer 8: Information Economics

Inspired by:

- George Akerlof

Buyers and sellers know different things.

Example:

You buy a used truck.

Seller knows:

- Engine is failing.

Buyer doesn't.

Markets become inefficient.

Layer 9: Network Effects

Inspired by modern technology economics.

Examples:

- Facebook
- WhatsApp
- Uber

The more users they have:

The more valuable they become.

Your game could allow businesses to become dominant through network effects.

Layer 10: Geography Economics

Inspired by:

- Paul Krugman

Location matters.

A village near:

- Ports
- Airports
- Cities



Develops faster.

Remote villages remain poor.

Layer 11: Cultural Economics

This is rarely simulated.

Different populations may have:

- Different risk tolerance
- Different trust levels
- Different family obligations
- Different savings behavior

Not because one is better.

Simply because culture affects incentives.

Layer 12: Political Economy

The biggest missing feature in most games.

Businesses influence government.

Government influences business.

Examples:

- Lobbying
- Subsidies
- Tariffs
- Corruption
- Elections

Many fortunes are made or lost here.

The Ultimate Vision

Instead of a Drug Lord clone, imagine:



"Economic Life"

Every citizen is simulated.

Each person has:

- Income
- Wealth
- Education
- Family
- Trust network
- Biases
- Goals
- Political beliefs
- Risk tolerance

They:

- Work
- Save
- Borrow
- Invest
- Start businesses
- Migrate
- Vote
- Marry
- Have children

Countries differ because of:

- Institutions
- Geography
- Culture
- Education
- Infrastructure
- Policies

A player could start as:

- Poor farmer in Dominica
- Shop owner in Jamaica
- Factory worker in Vietnam
- Banker in New York

And over decades see how economics, psychology, politics, and chance interact.

The fascinating part is that if built correctly, the game would become a laboratory for testing ideas from Smith, Keynes, Hayek, Kahneman, Thaler, Duflo, Acemoglu, and many other economists simultaneously. Players would discover that wealth is not determined by a single factor, but by the interaction of incentives, institutions, information, geography, culture, and human behavior.

I want to start building this game, but it should be as complex as reality. Players should be forced to think in real life before making a decision in the game for certain events.

You can build it, but there is a critical design decision you'll need to make early:

Do you want a game that is realistic, or a game that is as complex as reality?

Those are not the same thing.

If you make it as complex as reality, most players will quit because they won't understand why things happen.

For example, in real life:

- A farmer makes the correct decision.
- A hurricane hits.
- Export prices collapse.
- The government changes regulations.
- A bank fails.
- The farmer goes bankrupt.

That's realistic.

It's also frustrating if the player cannot understand the chain of causation.

The best simulations (e.g., Victoria 3, Crusader Kings III, Capitalism Lab) simplify reality while preserving the important incentives.

What I Would Build

Instead of simulating the world directly, simulate:

Decision Making

The player should constantly face trade-offs.

Real economics is not about maximizing money.

It is about making choices under constraints.

Every decision should have:

- Opportunity cost
- Uncertainty
- Delayed consequences

Example 1: Education

Most games do:

Spend \$5,000

Gain +5 Intelligence

Your game could do:

At age 18:

Option A

Attend university.

Effects:

- Lose income for 4 years.
- Accumulate debt.
- Gain future opportunities.

Option B

Start working immediately.

Effects:

- Immediate income.
- Miss certain careers.

Neither is obviously correct.

That mirrors reality.

Example 2: Farmer

Player has \$10,000.

A new fertilizer appears.

Research suggests:

- 60% chance harvest increases by 40%.
- 40% chance no improvement.

Do you:

- Invest?
- Wait?
- Borrow money and invest?

This is exactly the type of decision real farmers face.

Example 3: Migration

Player lives in Dominica.

Opportunity appears in:

- Canada
- United States
- Barbados

Questions:

- Leave family?
- Risk unemployment?
- Stay home?

There is no perfect answer.

Realistic Human Behavior

Most games make NPCs robotic.

Instead, every NPC should have:

Risk Tolerance

Some people:

- Save everything.

Others:

- Spend everything.
-

Trust

Some people:

- Trust strangers.

Others:

- Never trust strangers.
-

Ambition

Some people:

- Start businesses.

Others:

- Prefer stability.
-

Education

Influences:

- Decision quality.
 - Available opportunities.
-

Personality

Inspired by behavioral economics.

People should exhibit:

- Loss aversion.
 - Confirmation bias.
 - Herd behavior.
 - Overconfidence.
 - Anchoring.
-

Countries Should Not Be Equal

A major feature could be:

Starting in different countries produces fundamentally different experiences.

Example:

Developed Country

Pros:

- Better schools.
- Better healthcare.
- Better infrastructure.

Cons:

- Higher costs.
 - Higher competition.
-

Developing Country

Pros:

- Lower startup costs.
- More untapped opportunities.

Cons:

- Poor infrastructure.
- Weak institutions.
- Political instability.

This reflects ideas from development economics.

Force Real-Life Thinking

You mentioned wanting players to think like they would in real life.

One way is to remove perfect information.

Most games tell you:

This action has a 75% chance of success.

Real life rarely does.

Instead:

Government report:

Experts believe success is likely.

Friend says:

I heard it won't work.

News article:

Similar projects failed elsewhere.

Now the player must interpret imperfect information.

The Most Powerful Mechanic

I think the strongest mechanic would be:

The Consequence Delay System

Most games:

Decision → Outcome immediately.

Reality:

Decision → Outcome years later.

Example:

Age 20:

- Skip school.

Age 35:

- Certain jobs unavailable.

Age 50:

- Lower retirement savings.

The player experiences consequences long after the choice.

A Feasible Starting Version

If I were advising a startup building this game, I would not start with a whole world.

I would start with:

One Country

For example:

- Dominica

10,000 simulated citizens

Each citizen has:

- Age
- Income
- Wealth
- Education
- Occupation
- Personality traits
- Social network

Core Systems

1. Labor market
2. Education
3. Business creation
4. Banking
5. Government
6. Housing
7. Agriculture
8. Trade

Then add complexity gradually.

The most exciting possibility is that your game becomes a **living economics laboratory**. Players wouldn't just learn economics—they would discover why some people stay poor, why some businesses fail, why institutions matter, and why intelligent people can make very different decisions when facing the same situation. That's much closer to reality than simply building a bigger version of Drug Lord.

1) So what is your response to this, "Do you want a game that is realistic, or a game that is as complex as reality?"

2) I want the game where players in real life has to think, to make proper decision, which sometimes can be right but because of reality of life, still end up failing. What is the goal of the game?

1) My response to: "Do you want a game that is realistic, or a game that is as complex as reality?"

After hearing your vision, my answer is:

You should build a game that is as complex as reality underneath, but realistic to the player at the surface.

Think about real life.

When you make a decision, you don't see:

- GDP growth equations
- Monetary policy formulas
- Supply chain graphs
- Hidden personality variables of everyone around you

You simply experience the consequences.

For example, when deciding whether to start a fish export business, you don't know every variable affecting success. You know:

- Your savings
- What people tell you
- Market conditions
- Your confidence

Then reality unfolds.

Your game should work the same way.

The "Iceberg Model"

The player sees:

- News
- Prices

- Opportunities
- Rumors
- Experts
- Personal finances



Below the surface exists:

- Economic systems
- Social networks
- Institutions
- Behavioral biases
- Government actions
- Random events
- Demographic changes

The player should never fully understand the entire system.

Because nobody does in real life.

Why this matters

Imagine two players.

Player A:

- Studies markets carefully.
- Makes excellent decisions.

Player B:

- Acts impulsively.

Player A should generally outperform.

However...

A hurricane may destroy Player A's investments.

That is realistic.

But if Player A loses because the game simply rolled random dice, it feels unfair.

The player must be able to look back and say:

"I made the right decision. I just got unlucky."

That is exactly how real life often works.



2) What is the goal of the game?

This is the most important question you have asked so far.

If your game is truly about life, the goal cannot simply be:

Make the most money.

Because reality itself isn't optimized for money.

Many people willingly sacrifice wealth for:

- Family
- Health
- Faith
- Reputation
- Purpose
- Happiness

So I would not make money the primary objective.

Option 1: Wealth Maximization

This is the Drug Lord approach.

Goal:

Die with the most wealth.

Problem:

Players eventually discover the mathematically optimal strategy.

The game becomes an optimization puzzle.

Option 2: Happiness Maximization

Goal:

Live the happiest life.

Problem:

People disagree on what happiness means.



Option 3: Legacy Maximization

This is where I think your game becomes unique.

The objective becomes:

Build the greatest legacy possible.

Your legacy score could include:

Wealth

Did you create wealth?

Family

Did your children thrive?

Education

Did future generations become educated?

Community

Did your village prosper?

Reputation

Were you trusted?

Innovation

Did you create something useful?

Faith and Values

Did you live according to your principles?

National Impact

Did you improve your country?

A player could become:

A Billionaire

Score:

- Wealth: 100
 - Family: 10
 - Community: 5
-

Another player could become:

A Teacher

Score:

- Wealth: 30
 - Family: 80
 - Community: 95
-

Which life was more successful?

The game does not answer.

The player decides.

The Most Powerful Goal

I would make the goal:

Leave the world better than you found it.

Because then every decision becomes meaningful.

Should you:

- Exploit workers?
- Pay fair wages?
- Bribe officials?
- Protect the environment?
- Invest in education?
- Move abroad?

There is no perfect answer.

Only consequences.



The Twist

What would make your game extraordinary is this:

The player does not know how they are being scored.

Not completely.

Just like real life.

Nobody receives a dashboard showing:

- Happiness = 72%
- Legacy = 63%
- Moral score = 88%

Instead, at the end of the game, perhaps when the character dies, the player sees:

- Wealth accumulated
- Businesses built
- Family outcomes
- Community impact
- National impact
- Environmental impact
- Reputation

And only then discovers the story of the life they created.

At that point the game stops being a trading game.

It becomes a simulation of human existence viewed through economics, psychology, institutions, culture, and choice. That's a much more ambitious project than Drug Lord—but it's also something I've never seen done successfully at a truly realistic scale.

And also, if a player chooses a certain path/career/business market, the decisions that follow should be as realistic as possible, and the player should have knowledge of the domain in real life so they progress at a much faster rate or slower if they have little knowledge

That's actually one of the strongest ideas you've mentioned so far.

What you're describing is a game where **real-world knowledge becomes a competitive advantage**.

Most games reward:

- Time played
- Character levels
- Grinding
- Unlocks

Your game would reward:

- Knowledge
 - Judgment
 - Experience
 - Decision-making
-

Example: Agriculture

Suppose two players start a banana farm.

Player A

Knows nothing about farming.

The game presents:

- Soil reports
- Rainfall forecasts
- Fertilizer options
- Pest reports

Player A randomly chooses.

Player B

Actually understands farming.

He notices:

- Soil pH is too low.
- Rainfall forecasts suggest drought.
- Fertilizer A won't work well under those conditions.

Player B makes better decisions.

He advances faster.

Not because of game skills.

Because of real-world expertise.

Example: Trading

You already have trading experience.

Imagine your game includes:

- Futures markets
- Spot markets
- Arbitrage opportunities
- Risk management

A player who understands:

- Position sizing
- Probability
- Expected value

will outperform somebody who doesn't.

The game never explains these concepts.

Players either know them or learn them.

Example: Fishing Industry

Since you have experience around fisheries and cooperatives, imagine:

The game gives:

- Fuel prices
- Weather forecasts
- Fish stock reports
- Market demand

An experienced fisherman may realize:

Fuel costs are rising.

Fish prices aren't rising enough.

This trip will likely lose money.



A new player may not see it.

Example: Politics

Suppose the player becomes a minister.

The game presents:

- Budget deficits
- Unemployment
- Inflation
- Public opinion

Someone familiar with economics may understand trade-offs.

Someone unfamiliar may make decisions that sound good but create long-term problems.

The Problem

You must be careful.

If the game requires real-world expertise from the start, many players will quit.

Imagine:

Player starts a farm.

Game asks:

Should you apply potassium fertilizer at 60kg/ha?

Most people won't know.

The Better Approach

The game should allow three ways to succeed:

1. Existing Knowledge

Player already knows.

Fastest path.

2. Learning

Player studies.

Reads reports.

Experiments.

Eventually becomes knowledgeable.

3. Hiring Experts

Player pays specialists.

Agronomists.

Economists.

Lawyers.

Engineers.

This mirrors reality.

Hidden Knowledge System

I would implement something like:

Knowledge Level

Each field has a knowledge score.

Examples:

- Agriculture
- Finance
- Construction
- Medicine
- Politics
- Logistics

Knowledge determines:

Information Quality

Novice:

Crop failure risk: Unknown

Expert:

Crop failure risk: 37%

Opportunity Recognition

Experts see opportunities others miss.

Example:

A trader notices:

Price difference between Barbados and Dominica creates arbitrage.

Beginners never notice.

Decision Speed

Experts make decisions faster.

Beginners spend more time gathering information.

The Ultimate Goal

Eventually the game becomes:

A simulation where the player's real-world understanding directly influences outcomes.

Imagine:

A doctor excels in healthcare businesses.

An engineer excels in manufacturing.

A teacher excels in education policy.

A trader excels in financial markets.

A farmer excels in agriculture.

No game bonuses.

No artificial advantages.

Just better decisions.

The Most Interesting Outcome

After thousands of players, you might discover something fascinating:

People who are successful in real life may not be successful in the game.

Why?

Because reality contains luck, institutions, timing, and constraints.

A brilliant entrepreneur can fail because:

- A hurricane hits.
- Credit dries up.
- A competitor gets government support.

Likewise, an average entrepreneur can succeed because:

- They entered the right market at the right time.

That mirrors one of the deepest lessons of economics:

Good decisions improve your odds, but they do not guarantee success.

Your game could teach that lesson better than almost any economics textbook.

I want you know to tell me how you would design the game

If I were designing this game, I would stop thinking of it as a game and start thinking of it as a **Life & Society Simulator**.

The biggest mistake would be starting with businesses, trading, or economics.

Economics is actually the result of people making decisions.

So I would build the simulation in layers.

Layer 1: The Individual

Every person in the world is a simulated agent.

Each person has:

Hard Attributes

- Age
- Sex
- Education
- Occupation
- Health
- Wealth
- Income
- Debt
- Location

Personality Traits

- Risk tolerance
- Patience
- Trust
- Ambition
- Conscientiousness
- Generosity
- Impulsiveness

Behavioral Biases

Inspired by behavioral economics.

Examples:

- Loss aversion
- Overconfidence
- Anchoring
- Confirmation bias
- Herd behavior

No two citizens are identical.

Layer 2: Family

People belong to families.

Families affect:

- Education
- Values
- Wealth transfers
- Opportunities
- Social connections



This is huge.

Many real-life outcomes originate from family circumstances.

Layer 3: Social Networks

People know people.

A player's opportunities come from:

- Friends
- Family
- Colleagues
- Mentors

Many jobs are found through networks.

Many businesses are started through connections.

The game should reflect this.

Layer 4: Geography

The world matters.

A child born in:

- Dominica
- Haiti
- Singapore
- Switzerland

Should not experience the same opportunities.

Not because the game is unfair.

Because reality isn't equal.

Each country has:

- Infrastructure
- Institutions
- Corruption
- Education quality
- Healthcare quality
- Market size
- Political stability

Layer 5: Knowledge

This is where your idea becomes unique.

Knowledge is not a stat.

Knowledge is information.

Suppose the player enters agriculture.

The game does not say:

Click here for +10 farming.

Instead:

The player receives:

- Soil reports
- Market prices
- Weather forecasts
- Expert recommendations

Someone who understands farming gains an advantage.

Someone who doesn't must learn.

Layer 6: Career System

Every career is effectively its own game.

Farmer

Decisions:

- Crop selection
 - Fertilizer
 - Irrigation
 - Equipment
 - Export contracts
-



Teacher

Decisions:

- School quality
 - Student outcomes
 - Curriculum
-

Politician

Decisions:

- Taxation
 - Spending
 - Regulation
-

Trader

Decisions:

- Position sizing
 - Risk management
 - Arbitrage
-

Fisherman

Decisions:

- Fuel costs
- Weather risk
- Market timing
- Equipment investment

Each profession has unique mechanics.

Layer 7: Institutions

This is where most simulations fail.

Institutions determine opportunities.

Examples:

Property Rights

Strong:

- Investors invest.

Weak:

- Investors avoid risk.
-

Courts

Efficient:

- Contracts are enforceable.

Corrupt:

- Contracts become unreliable.
-

Government

Different systems create different outcomes.

The player experiences the consequences.

Layer 8: Economics

Only now do we create the economy.

The economy emerges from:

- Consumption
- Production
- Saving
- Borrowing
- Investment

Prices are not random.

Prices emerge from actual supply and demand.



Layer 9: Information

This is crucial.

Players never have perfect information.

They receive:

- News reports
- Expert opinions
- Rumors
- Social media

Some information is wrong.

Some is biased.

Some is incomplete.

Players must judge credibility.

Just like real life.

Layer 10: Time

The most important system.

Many consequences happen years later.

Example:

Age 18:

- Quit school.

Age 35:

- Limited career options.

Age 60:

- Lower retirement savings.

The game should reward long-term thinking.

Layer 11: Luck

Luck exists.

It must exist.

Examples:

- Hurricanes
- Illness
- Wars
- Technological breakthroughs
- Market crashes

However:

Luck should influence outcomes.

Not dominate them.

A skilled player should usually outperform an unskilled player over many decades.

Layer 12: Legacy

This would be the actual win condition.

When your character dies, the game evaluates:

Financial Legacy

- Wealth created

Family Legacy

- Children's outcomes

Community Legacy

- Impact on society

Innovation Legacy

- New ideas introduced

Institutional Legacy

- Organizations built

Environmental Legacy

- Resources preserved or destroyed



Reputation Legacy

- How history remembers you
-

The Core Gameplay Loop

Every in-game day:

You receive:

- Opportunities
- Information
- Problems

You make decisions.

The simulation updates.

New opportunities emerge.

The world changes.

You adapt.

The Secret Goal

The player should eventually realize something profound:

There is no perfect strategy.

A billionaire can die miserable.

A teacher can transform a nation.

A politician can become rich but damage society.

A farmer can leave behind a thriving family business.

The game should force players to answer:

"What does a successful life actually mean?"

Because that's the one question economics alone cannot answer.

And if you build that successfully, you won't have created a Drug Lord clone.

You'll have created something much closer to a simulation of human civilization itself.

Players decisions should affect society at different levels. For example, if a player has a business, and through a series of positive decisions, he business grows, it can become a monopoly. This will have an effect of society, governments can either force you to stop growing (Anti-trust laws), or in smaller countries, monopolies are granted favors from governments because of the bargaining power they have for the number of people they employ.

Also how do players gain skill points in game, how would you go about that? would you give them a real life test on subject matter, how are you planning on doing that?

Now you're getting into the part that could make the game genuinely different from every economic simulator I've seen.

1. Should player decisions affect society?

Absolutely.

In fact, I would argue that **the economy should not be the primary simulation. Society should be.**

The economy is simply one mechanism through which society changes.

For example:

Stage 1: Small Business

A player starts a grocery store.

Effects:

- Employs 2 people.
- Lowers local food prices.
- Pays taxes.

Society barely notices.

Stage 2: Regional Business

The player owns 20 stores.

Effects:

- Hundreds of employees.
- Influences suppliers.
- Influences wages.
- Influences local politics.

Now society begins reacting.

Stage 3: National Company

The player controls 60% of a market.

Effects:

- Can influence prices.
- Can influence wages.
- Can influence elections indirectly.
- Can negotiate tax incentives.

Now governments react.

Stage 4: Monopoly

This is where things become interesting.

Different countries respond differently.

Country A

Strong institutions.

Government may:

- Break up the company.
 - Fine the company.
 - Block acquisitions.
-

Country B

Weak institutions.

Government may:

- Grant tax holidays.
- Protect the monopoly.
- Provide subsidies.

Why?

Because:

"If this company leaves, unemployment doubles."

This is actually a realistic dilemma many governments face.

Stage 5: Systemic Importance

Eventually the company becomes:

"Too big to fail."

Now:

If your company collapses:

- Banks fail.
- Workers lose jobs.
- GDP drops.

Governments may rescue you.

Now you're playing at the level of national economic policy.

What I Would Simulate

I would track:

Economic Power

Market share.

Employment Power

How many jobs depend on you.

Political Power

Your influence.

Social Trust

How much society respects you.

Innovation Power

Your impact on productivity.

Media Influence

Your ability to shape narratives.

Different forms of power create different opportunities.

2. Skill Points

This is where I would depart from traditional games.

I would avoid "skill points."

The concept itself is unrealistic.

Real people don't gain:

+5 Agriculture

+10 Finance

Instead, I'd model:

Knowledge

Experience

Competence

as separate things.

Knowledge

What you know.

Can come from:

- School
- Reading
- Courses
- Mentors



Example:

A player learns:

- Accounting
- Economics
- Crop science

Knowledge increases.

Experience

What you've done.

A person may know farming theory.

But never planted a crop.

Experience is low.

Competence

The combination.

Competence grows when:

Knowledge × Experience

interact.

Real-Life Tests?

Yes.

But only partially.

This is actually one of the most innovative ideas.

Imagine:

Player wants to become a financial analyst.

The game presents actual scenarios.

Example:

A business earns:

- Revenue: \$100,000
- Costs: \$80,000

What is profit?

Simple.

Later:

A company can invest:

Project A:

- 60% chance +\$500k
- 40% chance -\$100k

Project B:

- Guaranteed +\$100k

Which has higher expected value?

Now the player's actual understanding matters.

But Don't Make It Mandatory

This is important.

There should be three paths.

Path 1: Real Knowledge

Player already knows.

Fast progression.

Path 2: Study

Player learns through in-game books, mentors, university.

Progression is slower.

Path 3: Hire Experts

Player doesn't understand finance.

Hires CFO.

CFO provides recommendations.

Progression costs money.

This mirrors reality perfectly.

The Most Realistic System

I think the best approach is:

No XP

No Levels

No Skill Points

Instead:

Each domain has:

Attribute	Meaning
Knowledge	What you know
Experience	What you've done
Reputation	What others think
Network	Who you know
Resources	What you can access

These five things determine success.

That's much closer to reality than a level system.



The Really Interesting Part

You could even allow players to become experts outside the game.

Suppose someone studies:

- Economics
- Agriculture
- Accounting
- Project management

in real life.

They return to the game and make better decisions.

The game effectively rewards actual learning.

Over time, players may discover that the fastest way to improve in the game is not grinding quests.

It's becoming more knowledgeable in real life.

That's a very unusual design philosophy—and it aligns perfectly with your goal of making decisions feel as consequential and reality-based as possible.

In business, people can buy other businesses outright by using saving or take loans, and the loans interest rates are determined by real life factors, your income, business income, current economics cycle, etc.

This is exactly how I would do it.

Most business games make loans far too simple:

Credit Score = 700



That's not how banks actually think.

In your game, a loan should be a **risk assessment problem**.

How a Bank Would Evaluate a Loan

Suppose you want to buy a fish processing company for \$2 million.

The bank examines:

Personal Factors

- Age
- Education
- Business experience
- Previous bankruptcies
- Reputation
- Existing debt

Business Factors

- Revenue
- Profit
- Cash flow
- Industry outlook
- Market share
- Customer concentration

Economic Factors

- Interest rates
- Inflation
- GDP growth
- Unemployment
- Political stability

Industry Factors

- Fisheries
- Tourism
- Agriculture
- Technology

Each industry has different risks.



Example

Two players request the same loan.

Player A

- Owns 3 profitable businesses.
- 15 years experience.
- Strong cash reserves.

Bank offers:

- 4.5% interest
- 20-year term

Player B

- New entrepreneur.
- No collateral.
- Recession underway.

Bank offers:

- 14% interest
- Requires collateral

or simply refuses.

The Hidden Risk Model

I would create a hidden score.

Not visible to players.

Something like:

```
Loan Risk Score =  
Business Risk  
+ Industry Risk  
+ Economic Risk  
+ Personal Risk  
- Collateral Strength
```



Banks use this internally.

Players never see it.

They only see outcomes.

Acquisitions

Now let's discuss buying businesses.

This is where most games become unrealistic.

Businesses should not have a fixed value.

They should be valued based on expected future earnings.

A player should ask:

| Is this business worth buying?

Not:

| Can I afford it?

Example:

Restaurant earns:

\$100,000 annually.

Owner wants:

\$2 million.

An experienced player realizes:

| This is overpriced.

Another business:

Earns:

\$300,000 annually.

Owner wants:

\$1 million.

Experienced player sees opportunity.

Leverage

This becomes very interesting.

Suppose:

Player has:

\$1 million

Finds:

\$10 million company

Can:

- Save for years
- Find investors
- Borrow money

Now they enter the world of leverage.

Economic Cycles

This is one thing I would absolutely model.

The same business should receive different loan offers depending on the economy.

During expansion:

- Easy credit
- Low interest rates
- Aggressive lending

During recession:

- Tight lending
- High rates

- Fewer approvals

This mirrors real life.

Bank Failures

The next step is making banks real entities.

Banks should:

- Have assets
- Have liabilities
- Make loans
- Hold reserves

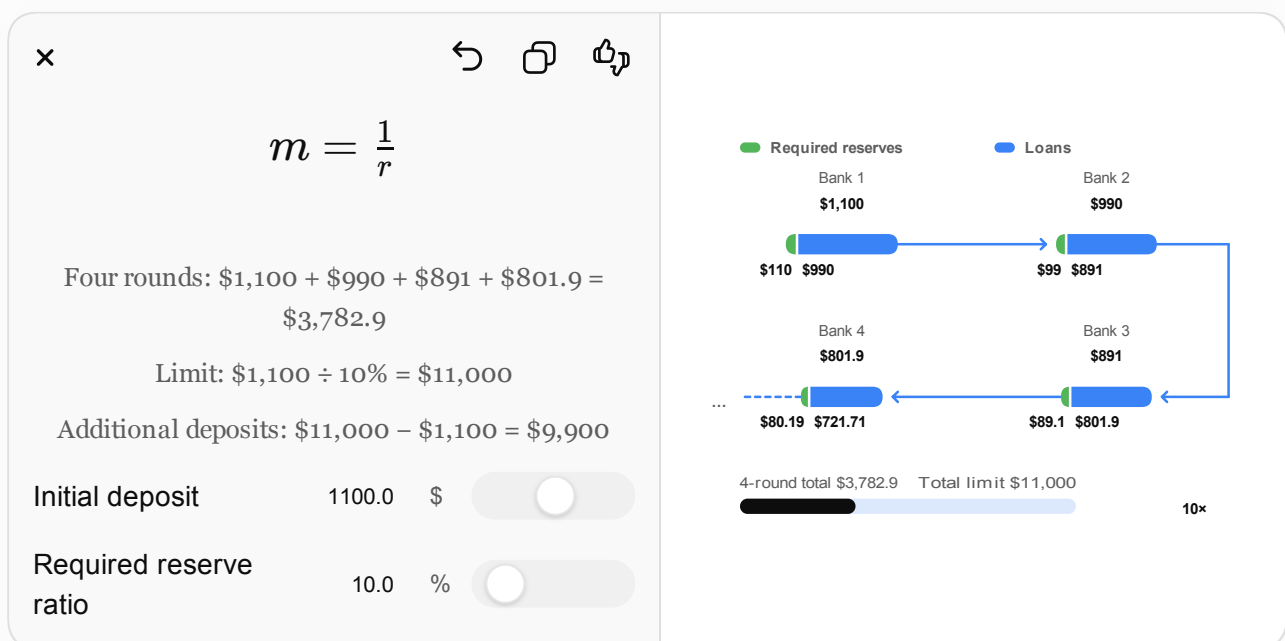
When too many loans fail:

Bank becomes insolvent.

Which then affects everyone.

The banking system itself becomes part of the simulation.

The basic textbook mechanism of reserve-based credit creation could even be represented by something like:



Not because players need the formula, but because credit availability affects how fast economies grow.

The Most Interesting Consequence

Imagine this scenario:

Player creates:

- Largest employer in Dominica.
- Employs 8,000 workers.

Player takes massive loans to acquire competitors.

Now:

- Banks depend on the player.
- Workers depend on the player.
- Government depends on the player.

Suddenly the player is not merely running a company.

They are becoming a systemic institution.

The government may:

- Investigate monopolistic behavior.
- Break up the company.
- Grant subsidies.
- Offer tax incentives.
- Protect the company from foreign competition.

And the government's decision would depend on:

- Political ideology.
- Public opinion.
- Employment levels.
- Election pressure.
- Corruption levels.
- Institutional quality.

At that point, you've moved beyond a business simulator and into a simulation of how power accumulates in real societies.

The key principle I'd follow is:

Every number in the game should come from a simulated reason.

Interest rates should not be random.

Business valuations should not be arbitrary.

Monopolies should not trigger scripted events.

Everything should emerge from the interaction of people, institutions, markets, governments, and incentives. When players start asking, "Why did this happen?" there should be an answer buried somewhere in the simulation. That's what will make the world feel alive rather than game-like.

1) And you have to be mindful, if a player has a monopoly, that means other business in the same industry might suffer, and if they have employees and loans, if they were to go out of business, then both unemployment and banks will lose money.

2) I want to start building the game. How would you go about it? React js? Java? Unity? Unreal engine? Godot? Gamemaker? etc. How would you go about building this game?

1) Monopoly Effects: You're Thinking in the Right Direction

What you're describing is **second-order and third-order consequences**, which is exactly what separates a true simulation from most management games.

Most games do:

Company grows → Player earns more money.

Your game should do:

Company grows → Competitors suffer → Suppliers become dependent → Banks increase exposure → Workers depend on company → Government becomes concerned → Society changes.

For example:

Stage 1: Local Dominance

Player controls 20% of grocery market.

Effects:

- Better purchasing power.
- Competitors feel pressure.

Stage 2: Regional Dominance

Player controls 60%.

Effects:

- Small stores begin closing.
- Unemployment increases.
- Banks start seeing loan defaults from competitors.

Stage 3: Monopoly

Player controls 90%.

Effects:

Consumers

- Lower prices initially.
- Higher prices later.

Workers

- More jobs.
- Less wage bargaining power.

Suppliers

- Dependence on monopoly.

Banks

- Large exposure to one company.

Government

- Growing concern.

Investors

- Increasing confidence.

Competitors

- Bankruptcy.

Now the interesting part:

Suppose the monopoly collapses.

Then:

- Thousands unemployed.
- Suppliers fail.
- Commercial property values fall.

- Tax revenue drops.
- Banks suffer losses.
- Government may need intervention.

This is how real economies behave.

The Rule I'd Use

Every entity should have dependencies.

Example:

Bank A

- └ Company X Loan (40%)
- └ Company Y Loan (20%)
- └ Mortgages (40%)

Company X

- └ 5,000 Employees
- └ 200 Suppliers
- └ 3 Banks

Government

- └ Tax Revenue from Company X (15%)

When Company X fails, consequences cascade.

This is called a **network effect simulation**.

2) How Would I Build This Game?

If I were building YOUR game specifically, I would **not** start with a game engine.

That's the biggest mistake new simulation developers make.

Your game is not primarily a graphics problem.

It's a simulation problem.

Architecture I Would Choose

Frontend

React + TypeScript

Why?

You already know React and TypeScript.

You can move faster.

Most of your game's complexity is menus, charts, data, reports, news, businesses, finances.

React excels at this.

Backend Simulation

Node.js + TypeScript initially.

Why?

Again:

You already know it.

Speed matters.

You need to validate ideas first.

Database

PostgreSQL ↗
.....

Not MongoDB.

I know you use Mongoose, but for this project I'd strongly recommend PostgreSQL.

Reason:

You'll have:

- Citizens
- Families
- Companies
- Loans
- Governments
- Markets
- Ownership structures

These are highly relational.

PostgreSQL is much better suited.

Phase 1

Don't build a game.

Build a simulation.

No graphics.

No map.

No animations.

No 3D.

No multiplayer.

Just:

Year 2026

Country:

Dominica

Population:

70,000

Businesses:

1,200

Banks:

4

Government:

1



Run simulation.

Observe outcomes.

Phase 2

Build a Dashboard

React frontend.



Show:

- GDP
- Unemployment
- Inflation
- Company rankings
- Wealth distribution

Think of it like a control panel.

Phase 3

Add Players

Now players can:

- Start businesses
 - Get jobs
 - Take loans
 - Invest
-

Phase 4

Add Real-Time World

Now:

- News
 - Economic cycles
 - Politics
 - Migration
-

Why Not Unity Yet?

Unity is amazing.

But Unity solves:

- Graphics

- Physics
- Animation



Your biggest challenge is:

Economics
Politics
Sociology
Behavioral economics
Business networks
Banking



Unity doesn't help much with those.

Why Not Unreal?

Unreal is even worse for your initial stage.

You'll spend months learning:

- Blueprints
- Materials
- Rendering
- Animation systems

Before solving:

How does a bank decide whether to approve a loan?

Why Not Godot?

Godot is actually a good future option.

But still:

Simulation first.

Engine later.

What I Would Personally Build

Year 1

Backend:

- TypeScript
- Node.js
- PostgreSQL

Frontend:

- React
- Material UI

Goal:

Create a functioning economy.

No graphics.

Year 2

Introduce:

- Maps
 - Citizens
 - Businesses
 - Governments
 - Banks
-

Year 3

Move simulation engine into:

- Rust
- or
- Java

Why?

Performance.

When simulating:

- 1 million citizens
- 100,000 businesses
- 50 years of economic activity

Node.js may become limiting.

Long-Term

My final architecture would probably be:

```
Frontend
├─ React
├─ TypeScript

API
├─ Node.js

Simulation Engine
├─ Rust

Database
├─ PostgreSQL

AI Agents
├─ LLM-assisted decision systems
```

If you asked me what to start building **this week**, I wouldn't start with a game screen.

I'd build these tables first:

```
Person
Family
Company
Industry
Country
Bank
Loan
Job
Market
Asset
```

Then I'd write:

```
simulateOneMonth()
```

and make the world run.

If that function can produce believable economic outcomes, you've solved the hardest problem in the entire project. Everything else—graphics, maps, animations, multiplayer—can be added later.

Is this conversation helpful so far?

